

An Stylo-phonological Analysis of ‘The Ride of Your Life’

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Introduction

Here, I will attempt to analyse at the phonological level the lyrics of the 2004 song “The Ride of Your Life” by The Gift of Gab. I would first describe the context of the song, and the research question I would like to answer. **Lyrics from [Genius.com](#) for academic fair use.**

Data

The song titled ‘The Ride of Your Life’ is the first track from rapper The Gift of Gab’s 2004 album 4th Dimensional Rocketships Going Up. According to last.fm it’s the most listened to track on the album. Structurally it’s small, only 3 minutes long. It has an intro verse, the main verse, and a long outro.

I found this song through [this video](#) on the YouTube channel **Stilou**, who analyses rap rhythm and rhyme schemes on his channel. It’s now one of my favourite songs, and the reason why I chose it for the paper.

Research Question

Being the intro track for a rap album it’s supposed to

1. Introduce the listener to the **technical skills** of the artist (something that is very important in rap), rather than have its own story and emotion.
2. Introduce the listener to the **essential theme** of the album.
3. **Make the listener inquisitive** to hear what the rest of the album would be like.

The song through its phonological architecture (which I will soon describe), constructs an experience of frictionless, continuous motion. The motifs, the musical harmony, position the listener on a seat in a rocketship journeying ‘through space and time’, while Gab, the MC’s firm, yet tender control guides and pilots this smooth and soulful journey.

I’m able to have this experience even though as a listener I usually ignore lyrics in general, focusing on the music, the rhythm and the lyrical ‘flow’ (defined later). This makes me particularly interested to analyse this song especially at the phonological level.

The question I attempt to answer here is, **What makes ‘The Ride of Your Life’ achieve this feeling through its phonological structure?**

Methodology and Limitations

By principle, Stylistics is eclectic and open, and to be able to analyse rap in the same way as poems, I have to adopt some terms from rap analysis.

What counts as a genuine, verifiable source for these terms? The most obvious problem with this analysis is with maintaining objectivity. Lupe Fiasco, widely considered to be one of the greatest rap lyricists, [presented](#) a class at MIT, ‘Rap Theory & Practice: an Introduction’, where he says, ‘[...] that rappers know *how* to do it,

but they don't know *what* they're doing. 'Cause rap was never formally trained. It was never put into an institution [...]' Lupe himself talks about foregrounding a lot here, but uses the term "surprise" instead, arguing its importance in life.

For that reason, I'd claim the verifiability of the sources doesn't matter, but rather it's important to understand that these terms are commonly understood as a part of the culture, the agreement does not come from fact-checking, but common agreement. This is my proof for objectivity for the assignment.

1. **Motif** is a short 'idea' in music, that reoccurs throughout the musical piece and gives the piece its characteristic.
2. **Rhyme** as a term covers more than just a standard rhyme. As a spoken form, the extent to which a rhyme needs to be perfect (as in two words having the same coda), [depends](#). Often in analyses that I've observed, even assonances are termed as rhymes. So maybe the better word should be **vocalic parallelism**, but I'd stick to the traditional term.
3. **Bar** is the musical measurement of distance, and I'd be replacing the term meter with this term. In rap specifically, a bar consists of 4 **beats**. There's almost a unanimous agreement in the community that rapping is done on a 4/4 time signature. Bars and beats provide the essential framework on which the words rest. The words can fall either directly on the beat (one two three four), or between two beats (one and two and three and four and), and even further divisions are possible. While a line in a poem can be structured in various ways, in rap, the end of a line commonly represents the end of a bar.
4. **Flow** is a term that I here would use to differentiate with rhythm, while rhythm deals with actual placement of words, flow to me is how it emits out of the mouth, whether the artist is rapping aggressively, or calmly, the speed, etc. This just exists here to make sure that I don't conflate it with rhythm.

Analysis

Background information

The rapper speaks the African American Vernacular Dialect of English, and hence words such as *riffin'* and *outta* are not foregrounded on account of being part of the individual style of the artist, or even the genre itself since rap is heavily influenced and shaped by black culture. Also, the song features the use of the pin-pen merger, where the vowels in pin and pen merge before nasals.

The motif

A motif represents something important in a song. Throughout the song, there are variations of some sort of oscillations, up and down motions and repetitions. The intro verse, and the verse at the start of the outro are the same. The harps that play in the background have notes played in arpeggio. The choir in the outro sings the same string of notes back to back. The flow of the main verse sounds somewhat similar, at the start of each bar the pitch of the rapper raises slightly, comes to normal, and then dips and comes back to normal again. The [I] type rhymes and the [O] type rhymes stay consistent throughout the main verse, such that they keep oscillating. Further it should be noticed that both of these rhymes are on the opposite points of the vowel quadrant: close-front and low-back.

The main verse

The song is divided into an intro, the main verse and a long outro. The song has no chorus.

The most interesting portion for a stylistic assessment is the main verse. Following up the motif introduced in the beginning, the entire verse, which has 18 bars, is rapped in one single breath. The flow is steady, and calm. Gab has a slightly husky voice that sounds soulful, and although an individual style, is very effective in this particular song and thus foregrounded.

Riffin in the octave of the
Infinite provocative
Come get within a rocket ship
Dimensions of a positive
Inventions that is monstrous
I'm givin' it my all
It's just my sentiments
Evolving as I give in
To the power of just livin' [...]

Following is a tabular view of where each syllable is landing on the beat. The first thing to mention about this is that each beat is further divided into four. The words fill every space possible. For a typical rap song post 1990, it's very common to have complex flows, where certain spaces are left blank to create certain effects. What is important about this particular song is the uniformity. The |I| rhymes fall on the 1st and 3rd beats, and the |O| rhymes fall at every 2nd and 4th beat. This stability continues the entire verse, since the intro is supposed to be the rocket preparing to take off, and the main verse is the rocket in space, and the outro is where it would come back down again.

•				•				•				•			
Rif-	fin	in	the	oct-	ave	of	the	in-	fi-	nite	pro-	vo-	ca-	tive	Come
get	with-	in	the	roc-	ket	ship	dim-	en-	sion	of	a	pos-	i-	tive	In-
ven-	tion	that	is	mons	-tr[ə]	-ous	I'm	giv-	in'	it	my	all	It's	just	my
sen-	ti-	ments	ev-	ol-	ving	as	I	give	in	to	the	power	of	just	liv-

The |I| and the |O| type rhymes have been named so (by me), because they somewhat minimally change during the expanse of the verse. For example in the third row above “all” has an [ɔ] while the ones above it have [ɑ], this change is not drastic, and is minimized even further by carrying that vowel over to the next |O| rhyme *evolving*, stabilizing the variation even further. And right after that it shifts to diphthong [aʊ], which continues till the end.

Further comments can be made about rhymes. Firstly, in rap, rhymes are one of the most used devices. Not only are there |I| and |O| rhymes. But there are further rhyme schemes that extend for more than a syllable, such as “provocative”, “a positive” to even “driven By the sound I feel it”, “liftin' Higher how my daily”. These are common ways rappers show their technical prowess in the language and also keep the song interesting and “catchy”.

What's much more interesting is how the ||| rhymes are often surrounded with other ||| type rhymes to make the transition between vowels in the front and top of the mouth to vowels in the back of the mouth easier. It enhances that floaty quality.

I would continue talking about the rhythm further but I should also point out one more thing about the flow. It's unbroken. Syllables from the next line fit seemingly perfectly in the ends of the previous bars, for example, In "(In)vention that is monstrous. I'm givin it my all. It's just my" fit inside a single bar, with the first syllable of "Invention" being placed right before the 1st beat of this bar. This creates continuity between the lines and further smoothens the flow, such that the verse resembles more a thread than a arrangement of lines.

I'd now point out two times where he breaks this rhythm and flow to put extra emphasis on words.

I'm **driftin'** on a **cloud** up in
 Your **mental** feel the **shower**
 Follow **in**, as I **devour**
 Y'all with **synonyms** and **vowels**
 Ladies and **gentlemen**
 It's **our** time to **dig** within a **tower**
 Over **ignorance**, the **final** hour's
Here so come and **crowd** around

•				•				•				•			
men-	tal	feel	the	show -	er	Foll-	ow	in	as	I	de-	vo-	ur	Y'all	with
sy-	no-	nyms	an d	vow-	els	Ladi es	and	gen	tle	men	It's	ou	-r	time	to
dig	with	in	a	tow	er	O	ver	ig	no	ranc e	the	fi	nal	ho	ur's

Firstly, "Ladies and gentlemen" somewhat breaks the almost perfect flow that continues up to now. This foregrounds the bar above the rest through apostrophe. It's a direct call to the listeners to listen to Gab's important message. Here, the words being emphasized through the rhyme schemes start feeling more important, "It's **OUR** time to **DIG** within a **TOWER** over **IGNORANCE**". Nextly the first syllables in "final" and "hour" both rhyme. This makes it foregrounded over other |O| type schemes, same thing happens with "crowd around".

Finally in the last line, the drums in the background stop while he finishes his verse with multiple strongly stressed words, and ends with a trochee. This has a semblance of falling down, as in the spaceship landing on the ground.

I **think** I've **really** **truly** **found** religion **now**

— ~ — ~ — ~ — ~ — ~ —

think I've real ly tru- ly found re- li- gion now

The intro verse

The intro verse is special in its own right, first through layout alone, it's visibly different from the main verse. Here, words can get unequal amount of time, so for instance some words would take $\frac{1}{4}$ of a beat, while others last $\frac{1}{2}$ of the beat, this creates more emphasis on certain words. It's slower in effect.

Enter in to the spacecraft filling up
That won't touch back again 'till the job is done
Way outta the range of normal
So far where ya are that ya no longer see the sun
It's a journey not of sight but sound
Ready or not you're bound
To also embrace the light
And drift on
Let your soul be again reborn
For these songs buckle up it's the ride of your life

The layout of the intro verse is like this. (B) stands for breath, It means that “Enter” starts offbeat, this means for longer lines, the syllable at the end starts the next bar. Instead of every beat being divided into 4 spaces, here it gets divided into 3. Again, the lines here don’t break. As mentioned previously this is Gab warming us for the main verse. The different amount of time each syllable takes feels mechanical, like an engineer repairing a machine, and cogs being turned. The rhyming pattern is spacious, with much less rhymes, which gradually develops by the end as we get to see “drift on”, “reborn”, “your”, “soul”, “re-born”, etc. The words being emphasized by the beats also change from being function words to lexical words like “soul”, “gain”, “born”, “songs”, and “ride of your life”. The placing of “life” here is such that both this word and the “Riffin” from the main verse start together.

•			•			•			•		
(B)	Ent-	er	in-	to	the	space		craft	fil-		lin'
up	that	won't	touch	back	a-	gain	'til	the	job		is
done	Way		out	ta	the	range		of	nor	mal	so
far	where	ya	are	that	ya	no	long	er	see		the
sun	It's	a	jour-	ney	not of	sight		but	sound	Ready	or
not	you're		bound		to	al	so	em	brace		the
light	And	drift	on	Let	your	soul	be	a	gain		re
born	for	these	songs	buck-	le	up	it's	the	ride	of	your
life	Riffin in the octave of ...										

Conclusion

Here I claimed that I don't listen to the semantic content of lyrics. And yet there is an effect produced in this song that makes me feel the way I described in the Introduction, through rhythm and harmony alone. And with my analysis, I feel like I've managed to prove the same.

Appendix

The full song

Lyrics from [Genius](#). **Academic fair use.** Additions and correction I made are marked with *.

[Intro]

Enter in to the spacecraft filling up
That won't touch back again 'till the job is done
Way outta the range of normal
So far where ya are that ya no longer see the sun
It's a journey not of sight but sound
Ready or not you're* bound
To also embrace the light
And drift on
Let your soul be again reborn
For these songs buckle up it's the ride of your life

[Verse 1]

Riffin in the octave of the
Infinite provocative
Come get within a rocket ship
Dimensions of a positive
Inventions that is monstrous
I'm givin' it my all
It's just my sentiments
Evolving as I give in
To the power of just livin'
In the now, I put the div-idends
I holler from the spirit
Within all of us
I'm driftin' on a cloud up in
Your mental feel the shower
Follow in, as I devour
Y'all with synonyms and vowels
Ladies and gentlemen
It's our time to dig within a tower
Over ignorance, the final hour's

Here so come and crowd around
And listen up on how I'm stayin' driven
By the sound I feel it liftin'
Higher how my daily livin' is
The styles are like my children
Seen scoured through the villages
And towns, and when the Gift
Is in the house
I bring the lyrics
That come down from up
Inherent to the sound
From a mysterious, profound
Very indigenous way out
Chief inner-vision, and
I think I've really truly found religion now

[Outro]*

Enter in to the spacecraft filling up
That won't touch back again 'till the job is done
Way outta the range of normal
So far where ya are that ya no longer see the sun
It's a journey not of sight but sound
Ready or not your bound
To also embrace the light
And drift on
Let your soul be again reborn
For these songs buckle up it's the ride of your life

FOURTH DIMENSIONAL ROCKETSHIPS,
GOING, UP

References

- The song itself: <https://youtu.be/RFE66SEwo7Y?list=RDRFE66SEwo7Y>
- Lyrics from Genius: <https://genius.com/Gift-of-gab-the-ride-of-your-life-lyrics>
 - This is usually the most credible source that I find online
- A short introduction to Rapping: <https://youtu.be/1ltyaFgMIT4?si=cgZ4vO6hP45-lweI>
- *Book of Rhymes: The Poetics of Hip-Hop* (2009) by Adam Bradley
 - I wanted to quote from this book earlier, but this was still very useful in the formulation of my methodology
- Lupe Fiasco's MIT presentation: <https://youtu.be/zBHRsYhYb-o?si=RxH03XXhCZLn1yEj>
- Stilou's video on The Ride of Your Life: <https://youtu.be/8UTpf2qKlk4?si=aBBjVIP5CxXzqDG0>
 - To take a further look at the insane amount of rhyme schemes in this song
- A reddit post detailing various kinds of rhymes:
https://www.reddit.com/r/makinghiphop/comments/8qtgpg/a_full_guide_on_how_to_rhyme_like_emi_nem/